and light the fuse, and then scamper away.

We wait for the blast, and wait, and wait. Has the fuse fizzled out?

No, it hasn't.

The firework goes off, and the massive explosion brings the entire playground to a standstill. All eyes turn toward the perpetrators and four 12-year-olds are soon standing before Principal Tom Beukes, trying hard to explain themselves. On this occasion, Stof and I get away with it. Chris and Skip take responsibility.

Stoffel de Beer has become a successful businessman, initially with South African Breweries and more recently with Toyota, but for the other three of us, he'll always be a kind-hearted softie; reputations earned at an early age have tended to stick.

'His parents have said Stof can come for a sleepover,' my mother announced one morning in 1990.

Stof and I were both six years old and, in our world, this was very big news. The De Beer family lived on a farm 10 kilometres outside Warmbaths, and we lived in town. I was excited.

Everything went well and the next morning I suggested we hit some golf balls around the garden. I had been given a nine-iron for my birthday – my Christmas and birthday presents were always sports equipment – and I was eager to show Stof. Unfortunately, he started crying; he was missing his mother.

'Come on, Stof, you'll be OK,' I said. 'It'll be fun.'

'Sorry, man,' he replied, 'I'm not going to make it.'

'So what do you want to do?'

'I want to go home.'

'Your mom is coming to collect you this afternoon.'

'I know, but I want to go home now. I want to walk home. Will you come with me?'

Disappointment instantly turned to excitement. Walking 10 kilometres to the De Beer farm sounded like a great adventure. I quickly